Questions for product managers

Design Gurus

The round does not change when you interview for a manager role. The evidence does.

The scope of I gets harder

An engineer can say "I found the race condition and shipped the fix." A manager rarely has a sentence like that, because other people did the work.

Two failures follow from that, and they are opposites.

Claiming the team's work. Describing what your team shipped as though you built it. A follow-up question about a technical decision exposes this quickly.

Disappearing from your own story. Saying "the team decided" and "we delivered" throughout, so nothing attaches to you at all.

What the interviewer needs is your decisions. You chose what the team worked on, who worked on it, what you cut, when you escalated, and what you did when it went wrong. Those are actions and they are yours.

Here is a useful test. If the story would be identical told by anyone else on the team, it is not a manager answer yet.

The Result changes shape

For an engineer, the Result is usually what the system did afterwards. For a manager it is usually one of three things.

What the team produced. Delivery, quality or speed, with a number.

What changed about the team. Attrition, how long a new joiner takes to ship, how many people can now do something only one person could do before.

What changed outside the team. A decision other teams adopted, or a process that outlived you.

At least one of your stories should have a person as its result rather than a system. Most managers arrive without one, and it is the clearest single signal of the job.

Three categories change completely

Six of the nine categories are answered much the same way you always did. Three are different.

Initiative and leadership stops being about proposing an idea. It becomes choosing between two things your team could do, and naming the cost of the one you dropped.

Managing constraints and setbacks stops being about a technical limit. It becomes about

people, headcount and time.

Collaboration and teamwork stops being about working with a difficult colleague. It becomes about managing one.

Level still applies inside management

The same calibration runs through the management ladder. A line manager is assessed on their own team. A manager of managers is assessed on how they set direction for people they do not see every day.

If you are interviewing one level up, emphasize the part of the story where something changed beyond the people who reported to you.

What to do next

Read the lesson for your role, then go back to your story bank and check two things.

That at least one story has a person as its result. And that in every story, somebody else reading it could say what you personally decided.